

they would never agree with.

"I'm from an extremely orthodox Muslim family. Back when I was in school and in college, I would wear the burkha. I couldn't even think of leaving the house if I wasn't wearing the burkha. While my parents were supportive of my education, they would have drawn the line at my getting into a sport like martial arts. So I used to wear the burkha when I left home. Then, when I went into the gym, I would change into my gear and back into the burkha when I was heading back home. It almost felt like I was living two lives. I tried to balance those two lives as much as possible. I knew I would have to tell my family eventually, but I was hoping I could ease them into it," she says.

It was at the Combat Kinetics Gym where she felt she truly belonged. "Because I had been somewhat sporty in the past, I didn't really struggle getting physically in shape. I enjoyed doing all the pushups and pullups. I absolutely loved actual combat training. A lot of our training in MMA is mixed gender, and I sometimes would think just how scandalised my family would be if they walked in on one of our grappling sessions. But I genuinely didn't think too much about it when I started. I just got on with it. It wasn't as if I'd stopped becoming religious or stopped praying, but I think it's what's inside your heart that counts a lot more than what you are wearing on the outside," she says.

Afshan says she knew she was meant to be a fighter when she stepped into the fighting cage for her first sparring session. "In contrast to a lot of the other individuals who were starting out, I was also someone who wasn't scared of sparring. A lot of beginners are scared of being hit. They close their eyes and turn their heads. When they get hit on the face for the first time, they decide this isn't what they want to do with their life. But fighting just came naturally to me," she says.



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Her biggest fight would come outside the cage when her parents eventually found out that she was training in mixed martial arts. "My dad freaked out. There was a lot of screaming. They took away my phone, and I wasn't allowed to leave the house for a week. But I kept insisting that I would go, and eventually my parents gave in," she says.

Over time, Afshan's parents have come to terms with her choices. "I don't think my father and mother were personally against my taking up MMA. I think they were more concerned about what the society I came from would think about what I did. I think they first thought it was a weird sort of fad that I had picked up. Initially, as a compromise, my father would drive me to the classes

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IT WAS ONLY AFTER HER SCHOOL WHEN SHE BEGAN STUDYING FOR A DEGREE IN ELECTRICAL ENGINEERING AT HINDUSTAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY THAT AFSHAN SAYS SHE FINALLY GOT THE CHANCE TO PURSUE HER PASSION
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and bring me back right after. Later, I learnt how to drive a motorcycle and began to go myself. That gave him the confidence that I was really serious about what I was doing," she says.

Within a few months of training, Afshan says she was sure combat sports was what she wanted to do with her life. "I can say I was a quick learner. As part of our training, we